Stop using someone else's AI

There is an odd thing about the AI boom. We have spent the last few years talking about bigger models, bigger clusters and bigger companies, but one of the most important shifts in AI is happening in the opposite direction: more of the technology is moving into the hands of ordinary builders.

That matters because simply running an AI model is no longer the hard part. If you followed the first part of this series, you already know how to choose an open model, download it, quantise it, benchmark it and make it run on hardware you control. The more interesting question begins now: what do you do with it?

The scale of the opportunity is difficult to overstate. Stanford's 2026 AI Index says 88 percent of organisations now use AI in at least one business function. McKinsey puts the figure at 89 percent, while 44 percent of organisations say they are already scaling AI across the enterprise, up from 38 percent a year earlier. Yet only about 6 percent qualify as AI "high performers" that attribute at least 5 percent of EBIT to AI and describe its financial impact as significant. In other words, almost everybody has access to AI. Far fewer have worked out how to turn it into something genuinely useful.

That gap is where this book lives.

Open AI development is no longer a niche hobby either. Hugging Face reported more than 13 million users, over two million public models and more than 500,000 public datasets by the end of 2025. By August 2026, the Hub had crossed three million public models. Meta says its Llama family alone has been downloaded more than 1.2 billion times. On GitHub, AI-related repositories have passed 4.3 million, while 1.1 million public repositories now import an LLM SDK, a figure that jumped 178 percent in a year.

India is not watching this revolution from the sidelines. GitHub counted 21.9 million developers in India in 2025, after the country added more than 5.2 million in a single year. India also became the world's largest contributor base to public and open-source projects. Meanwhile, the Government of India says the IndiaAI Mission has established access to more than 38,000 GPUs through 14 cloud partners, while AIKosh had onboarded 3,011 datasets and 243 AI models from 39 organisations across 20 sectors by the end of FY2025-26.

Those numbers change the meaning of "build your own AI". Five years ago, the phrase sounded like a project for a hyperscaler or a well-funded research lab. In 2026, it can mean a journalist building a research assistant over years of notes, a small business creating an internal support bot, a developer teaching a compact model to follow a specialist workflow, a student building a multilingual tutor, or an enterprise connecting an open model to private documents and internal tools without sending every query to an external chatbot.

And crucially, building your own AI rarely means training a foundation model from zero. The smarter route is usually to take a capable existing model and add the layers that make it yours.

Give it your knowledge through retrieval-augmented generation. Give it the right behaviour through prompts, examples or fine-tuning. Give it access to functions and software through tools. Wrap it in an interface people can actually use. Then evaluate the entire system rather than assuming that a convincing answer is a correct one.

That final point deserves emphasis. AI capability is improving so quickly that the 2026 AI Index found frontier models gaining around 30 percentage points in a single year on Humanity's Last Exam. Yet the same report notes that AI agents still fail roughly one in three attempts on structured computer-use benchmarks, while hallucination rates in one knowledge-and-belief benchmark ranged from 22 percent to 94 percent across 26 leading models. Powerful is not the same thing as reliable.

Which is exactly why owning the build matters.

When you control the data, retrieval, prompts, model, tools and evaluation process, AI stops being a mysterious box at the other end of an internet connection. It becomes a system you can inspect, modify and improve.

If last month's *Fast Track* helped you put an open model on your machine, this month we turn that model into something worth keeping.